

NEBRASKA OWNER-BUILDER PERMIT KIT

One code everywhere · A permit almost nowhere · An inspector at the meter

Project Address: _____

City / Village: _____

County: _____

Building Permit Office: _____

Electrical Inspection: _____

Owner-Builder: _____

Building permit office may honestly be NONE. Electrical inspection never is:
write STATE or the name of the local program — NE.4 shows you how to look it up.

Every Nebraska statute, rule and requirement in this kit
is cited on the page it appears on — verified September 2026.

BUILD YOUR HOUSE

build-your-house.com

First Edition — 2026

How to Use This Kit

Five working documents, from "what binds my house and who can stop me?" to the last inspection.

Nebraska has **one** state building code — the 2018 International Residential Code and the 2018 Uniform Plumbing Code, adopted by statute — and the statute then says something almost no other state says: that code is "the legally applicable code **regardless of whether** the county, city, or village has provided for the administration or enforcement" of it. The code binds your house everywhere. **Nobody has to issue a permit or inspect it**, and no state agency may.

So the question most kits in this series spend a document on — *does the code apply to me?* — has a one-word answer here, and the question that actually decides your build is a different one: **who, if anyone, can stop you?** Outside the cities and counties that chose to run a building department, the answer is three offices that do not depend on one: the **State Electrical Division**, whose inspection is enforced by the power company at the meter; the **energy code**, which the statute makes you enforce on yourself; and the **septic and well filings**, made by the licensed professional or by you.

Two things about that arrangement catch almost everybody. Your right to wire your own house is a **license** exemption, not an inspection exemption — and since **July 18, 2026**, failing to file the request for that inspection is a **felony**. And you may drill your own well on your own homestead, but you may **not** install your own septic system: a certified installer must be physically on the site.

WHAT IS IN THE KIT

The five documents

	Document	What it does for you
NE.1	What Binds You and Who Can Stop You	The sentence that makes the code apply without a building department, the four state obligations that reach every house, what you may do with your own hands, and the registration act that governs everyone you hire. Read this first.
NE.2	Permit Application Checklist	What to gather before you file — the code editions actually in force, the five electrical sections still on the 2017 text, the energy values, the radon rule and its two exemptions, the septic and well packages with their setbacks and fees.
NE.3	Inspection Sequence	The one inspection track the statute fixes — electrical, with its one-week clock and five-month permit life — the two mandatory registrations, the 2026 rule on virtual inspections, and what to do where nobody is required to inspect you.
NE.4	Where to File Directory	The state map that tells you who inspects electrical at your address, the three-step check for whether a building permit exists, the state offices, Lincoln and Sarpy County worked, and a page to record what you confirmed.

The five documents

	Document	What it does for you
NE.5	Forms & Documents Index	Each document you will meet, named as the agency names it — plus the paper Nebraska never asks you for, and the one thing you may not do yourself.

HOW TO USE IT

- **Start with NE.1.** Its first pages settle what the code requires of you whether or not anyone checks, and which of the four statewide obligations will actually reach your parcel. Nothing else in the kit sequences correctly until you have that straight.
- **File the electrical request for inspection before you start wiring.** This is the single most expensive mistake in Nebraska. The request is due "at or before commencement," a late one costs \$250, the utility may refuse to connect you without your certificate that it was filed, and not filing at all is now a Class IV felony. None of that depends on whether your county has a building department.
- **Then deal with the septic system.** On a rural Nebraska build the septic professional is the longest pole — you cannot install the system yourself — and the setback table decides where the house can sit.
- **Keep NE.3 on the job** and record every inspection and filing as it happens — most of all where nobody is required to inspect you. The electrical approval and the septic and well registrations may be the only third-party evidence your house ever gets, and a buyer's lender will ask for it.

How these facts were checked — and what this is not

Every Nebraska claim here was read against its primary source in September 2026 — the Revised Statutes as the Legislature publishes them, the 2026 slip laws, the agencies' own rule titles and forms, and the State Electrical Division's inspection map — and is cited where it appears. Where the answer genuinely depends on your city or county, the kit says so and gives you a line to write down what you confirmed. Not legal advice.